

Counselor Heads-Up and Opt-Out Toolkit

Teacher Support

Trust your hackles. Pause · Check · Tell.

FIELD COPY

1



Lock It

PASSWORDS AND ACCOUNTS

2



Spot It

SCAMS AND FAKES

3



Share Smart

PRIVACY

4



Safe People

WHO TO TRUST

5



Kind and Well

KINDNESS AND BALANCE

6



Fix It

TELL, REPAIR, RECOVER

PLATE I. The six strands, hand-inked, in the order the lessons take them.

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OCTOBER 2026

Hackles Teacher Support Pack, Document 5 of 5. For teachers, counselors and administrators running sensitive lessons.

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TO VERIFY

Consult counsel and policy. Rules on parent notification, opt-out and parental rights vary by state and district. Some states require advance notice or allow opt-out for sensitive instruction, and some don't. Check with your administrator and district counsel before you use these templates. [VERIFY]

01 Which lessons are "sensitive"?

THESE LESSONS ARE LIKELIER to prompt disclosures or strong reactions, so for each one, give the counselor a heads-up and send families a pre-notice, and do both early enough that nobody is scrambling.

BAND	LESSON	WHY IT IS SENSITIVE
K-2	9. My Body Is Mine	Body safety, telling about unsafe requests
K-2	6. Online Friends vs. Real Friends	Secrets and unsafe contact
3-5	6. Game Chat Red Flags	Grooming warning signs, secrecy, pressure
3-5	1. The Help Ladder	Role-play of telling about worries
6-8	6. Grooming Patterns	Trust-building, secrecy, isolation
6-8	7. Pressure Online: Response Drill	Sextortion response
6-8	8. Fakes That Hurt	Deepfake and "nudify" abuse
6-8	1. Help Ladder: Real Practice	Disclosure rehearsal
9-12	5. Sextortion and Image Abuse	Sextortion, legal context
9-12	7. Coercion in Relationships Online	Digital control, consent
9-12	8. Be the Helper	Friends in crisis, self-harm
6-8	Plus P1. Work, Pressure and Promises Online	Human trafficking and exploitation. Specialist review required before use. Family pre-notice, opt-out and alternate ("Job Scams")
6-8	Plus P2. Scroll Science	Mental health, loneliness, compulsive use; hopelessness card. Counselor or clinician review required before use. Family note; opt-out honored; alternate ("My Limits")

BAND	LESSON	WHY IT IS SENSITIVE
9-12	Plus P1. Recruitment Online	Human trafficking and exploitation, recruitment, debt and control. Specialist review required. Family pre-notice, opt-out and alternate ("Spot the Scam")
9-12	Plus P2. Mind, Mood, and the Scroll	Mental health, self-image, hopelessness vignette. Counselor or clinician review required. Family note; opt-out honored; alternate (Two-Week Experiment with the counselor)

Lesson numbers follow the Stage 1 scope and sequence. If your scope changes, update this table.

Recommended heads-up (not a formal pre-notice). 6-8 Plus P3 (misinformation), 9-12 Plus P3 (platform design) and Plus P4 (cyberbullying) are not sensitive lessons. Even so, students may disclose that they're being targeted, that they can't stop scrolling, or that they feel low, so a short counselor heads-up is recommended, and a known rumor or bullying incident in the class is a good reason to talk first.

Florida note. In Florida, the statute read for this kit provides a parent exemption only for reproductive health and disease instruction (s. 1003.42(5)), so an opt-out from a Hackles lesson is a district or school policy choice, and the alternate activity must still teach the component [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: leg.state.fl.us 1003.42(5); VERIFY the district's policy]. The trafficking Plus lessons (P1 in both bands) must not be taught until a trafficking-prevention specialist has reviewed them; the mental-health Plus lessons (P2 in both bands) must not be taught until a school counselor or clinician has. See 20_Florida/District_Adoption_Guide.md.

02 Timeline

WHEN	WHO	WHAT
3 weeks before	Administrator, counselor	Confirm which lessons are sensitive, check policy on notice and opt-out, confirm counselor availability
2 weeks before	Teacher	Send the family pre-notice (Family Engagement Pack) with the lesson overview and a review option
1 week before	Teacher, counselor	Offer family preview session or viewing time. Collect opt-out requests. Arrange alternatives.
2 days before	Teacher	Counselor heads-up message (Section 3). Confirm coverage.
Day of lesson	Counselor	Be on call and available. Hold a drop-in space.
Day of lesson	Teacher	Use the calm opening and closing scripts. Offer the "ask the counselor" option.
24 hours after	Teacher, counselor	Debrief. Check in with any student who was upset. Document any disclosures per the Disclosure Guide.
1 week after	Teacher	Send a follow-up note to families with the take-home card and Family Reply slip.

03 Counselor Heads-Up message (template)

FIELD NOTE	No. 1
To: [Counselor name] From: [Teacher name] Subject: Heads-up: sensitive lesson on [date and period] Hello [Name], I will teach "[Lesson title]" to [class/grade] on [date] during [period/time]. The lesson covers [one-sentence plain description, for example: "recognizing when someone online is pressuring you for pictures and practicing how to tell a trusted adult"]. It does not include graphic content. Because lessons like this can prompt students to share things or to feel upset, could you please: - Be available (or have a backup) on [date] from [time] to [time]? - Let me know the best way to reach you during the lesson (room, phone, a student-delivered note)? - Tell me if there are students you know would benefit from a private check-in before or after? - Let me know if you would like to join the lesson, or co-teach the last five minutes? I have sent the family pre-notice on [date]. [Number] opt-out requests so far: [list or "will update"]. I will use the Disclosure and Incident Guide if a student discloses, and will bring any concerns to you the same day. Thank you, [Teacher name]	

04 Counselor checklist for sensitive lesson days

- ☐ I know which classes have the lesson and when.
- ☐ I am free (or have coverage) during and right after each lesson.
- ☐ I have a quiet, private space ready for students who need it.
- ☐ I have the list of students with opt-outs and their alternative arrangements.
- ☐ I have the list of students already receiving support who may need a pre-lesson check-in (handled confidentially).
- ☐ I have fresh copies of the Disclosure and Incident Record and know my reporting steps. [VERIFY policy]
- ☐ I know who the administrator on call is and how to reach them.

- ☐ I have resource information ready: 988, Crisis Text Line, NCMEC CyberTipline, Take It Down [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: official sites of the named services]. In Florida, also the Florida Abuse Hotline 1-800-962-2873, the Florida Human Trafficking Hotline 1-855-FLA-SAFE and the National Human Trafficking Hotline 1-888-373-7888 [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: myflfamilies.com; fdle.state.fl.us; humantraffickinghotline.org/en/contact].
- ☐ For Plus P1 and P2: I confirmed the specialist or clinician review is done, and I have the names of students (kept confidential) who may need a private word first, including students in foster care, students who work, and students who have lost someone recently.
- ☐ I have a plan for supporting the teacher after any disclosure.
- ☐ I have the school-level summary form ready to track (without student names) how many disclosures and referrals followed.

05 Scripts

CALM OPENING (READ ALOUD BEFORE A SENSITIVE LESSON)

"Today we're going to talk about what to do when someone online makes you feel uncomfortable or pressured. We won't talk about anything graphic. You are never in trouble for telling a trusted adult. If anything today makes you feel worried or upset, you can take a break, draw instead of talk, or ask to see [counselor]. You don't have to share anything personal in front of the class. Is that okay with everyone?"

CALM CLOSING (READ ALOUD AFTER)

"Thank you for working so hard today. Here is the most important thing: if anything online ever makes you feel scared, pressured, or confused, you are not in trouble, and you can tell a trusted adult. Let's name our trusted adults. [Students name or point to people.] If something came up for you today, you can talk to me, to [counselor], or write a note and put it in the box. Let's take one slow breath together."

IF A STUDENT REACTS STRONGLY DURING THE LESSON

"I can see this is a lot right now. Would it help to take a break? You can sit in the calm corner, get some water, or go with [name] to see [counselor]." Do not single the student out in front of peers. Follow up the same day.

IF A STUDENT DISCLOSES IN CLASS

"Thank you for telling me. I'd like to talk with you more privately, in a moment. Let's keep going for now." Then follow the Disclosure and Incident Guide.

06 The opt-out process

PRINCIPLES

- **Parents and caregivers are partners.** Notification exists to build trust. Defensiveness only gets in the way.
- **Be transparent.** Share the lesson summary, the materials for review, and the learning goals.
- **Opt-out should never penalize the student,** academically or socially.
- **Never ask the student to explain the family's decision.**
- **The safety message still reaches the child,** in a way that fits the family's wishes and the law. See the alternative options below.
- **Confirm the rules** with your administrator: in some states and districts opt-out is required, optional, or not allowed for particular topics. Separately, federal law (PPRA) requires districts to let parents inspect instructional materials, and any survey or screening that asks students about the eight protected areas (including mental or psychological problems and sex behavior or attitudes) needs advance written parental consent, not just an opt-out, per the US Department of Education's August 26, 2026 letter. [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: studentprivacy.ed.gov; law.cornell.edu/uscode/text/20/1232h] State rules vary; confirm with district counsel.

STEPS

1. **Send the pre-notice** with an opt-out or review form (see the sensitive-topic pre-notice in the Family Engagement Pack).
2. **Offer a review.** Invite families to preview the materials in person, by phone, or on paper, whichever suits them, and don't make them ask twice.
3. **Receive the request** from the family in writing (form or email), and keep it in the confidential file.
4. **Acknowledge warmly.** "Thank you for letting us know. We want to support your child. Here are the options..."
5. **Offer alternatives** (see below).
6. **Arrange a respectful alternative activity** for the lesson period, without labeling the child. For example: quiet reading or a library activity, a general kindness or screen-balance activity, or a counselor-led small group on safe adults and help-seeking.
7. **Make sure the child knows the core help message** in family-approved language: "If anything ever worries you, tell a grown-up you trust. You are never in trouble."

8. **Share the take-home materials** with the family, so they can teach the topic in their own way.
9. **Record** the opt-out and the alternative in the confidential file, per policy.
10. **Review it every year.** Families can change their minds at any time.

ALTERNATIVE OPTIONS TO OFFER

OPTION	DESCRIPTION
Review first	The family previews the full lesson and decides. Many opt-outs become participation after review.
Family-led version	The family receives the take-home card and conversation starters and teaches the topic at home.
Counselor session	The student attends a short counselor-led session on trusted adults and help-seeking with no lesson-specific content.
Modified participation	The student joins the lesson but sits out role-plays or certain parts.
Alternative lesson	A general lesson from the same strand, such as Kind Clicks, Screen Balance, or Passphrase Lab.
Plus-lesson alternates	Plus P1: "Job Scams" (6-8) or "Spot the Scam: Job Offers That Ask for Your ID" (9-12), which teach the same flags and reporting card with a non-exploitation scenario. Plus P2: the My Limits plan (6-8) or the Two-Week Experiment card with the counselor (9-12). Each alternate must still reach the component: hand over the reporting or help card.

WHAT TO SAY TO A FAMILY WHO IS CONCERNED

- "I can hear you care a lot about your child. Thank you for contacting me."
- "Would you like to see the lesson? I can walk you through it, and I'm glad to answer questions."
- "The lesson uses no graphic content. It focuses on telling a trusted adult."
- "If you prefer to opt out, we'll respect that and offer an alternative. We will make sure your child knows who to tell if something ever worries them."

WHAT NOT TO SAY

- "Your child will be left out."
- "You're keeping them unsafe."
- "Everyone else is doing it."
- Anything that questions a family's values or parenting.

07 Opt-out request form (template)

FIELD NOTE	No. 2
Family Request Regarding Sensitive Lesson Student name: _____ Grade/class: _____ Lesson: _____ Date: _____ Please check one: ☐ I have reviewed the materials and my child may participate. ☐ I would like to review the materials before deciding. Please contact me at: _____ ☐ I would like my child to participate in an alternative activity for this lesson. ☐ I would like to teach this topic at home. Please send the take-home materials. Language I prefer for communication: _____ Comments or questions (optional): _____ Parent or caregiver signature: _____ Date: _____ <i>Our school will make sure your child knows who to tell if anything ever worries them. Your decision will not affect your child's grades or standing. Please return by [date].</i>	

08 After the lesson: follow-up for counselors

- Collect the names (confidentially) of students who asked to talk, looked visibly upset, or disclosed.
- Check in with those students the same day, while it is still fresh and before the weekend gets in the way.
- With the teacher and administrator, decide whether a family contact or report is needed, per policy and law. [VERIFY]
- Offer small groups to students who share a concern, such as being targeted online or supporting a friend.
- Send the administrator a short anonymous summary: lessons delivered, referrals, themes, needs. No names.
- Look after the teacher. The Disclosure and Incident Guide has a self-care section.

09 Common concerns from administrators and families

CONCERN	SUGGESTED RESPONSE
"Won't this give kids ideas?"	The lessons teach recognition and response, not how to commit harm. They give children words to say no and tell. Research on prevention education suggests skills-based teaching, not fear, is more effective [VERIFY Finkelhor et al., 2021].
"This should be taught at home."	We agree families are the primary educators. We provide materials to support that conversation, and children benefit when school and home share the same message.
"My child is too young."	Lessons are age-banded and use simple, non-graphic language. Younger grades focus on body safety, telling a trusted adult, and not keeping unsafe secrets.
"What if it upsets my child?"	A counselor is on call, students can take breaks, and families can review materials or opt out.
"What if a child discloses?"	Staff are trained to listen, reassure, and report, following district policy and state law.
"Is this required?"	Some states and federal rules require online-safety education. Check with your administrator. [CIPA requirement VERIFIED 2026-10-05: usac.org/e-rate/applicant-process/starting-services/cipa ; state mandates vary, so confirm yours with your administrator]

This toolkit is general guidance, not legal advice. Consult counsel and district policy.